COLONIAL THEATRE

Church, School and Concert: The Colonial Stages

A ZikShare teaching unit, written for this shelf

The three stages where colonial Nigerians performed, and the repertory each one produced - from the nativity play to the Yoruba folk opera.

WHAT THIS UNIT COVERS

- the nativity play
- the cantata
- speech day
- the folk opera
- the hall

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The church

Mission Christianity brought drama in its liturgy and then in its festivals. The nativity play, the Passion play and the Easter cantata gave Nigerian congregations a ready-made dramatic repertoire, a rehearsal calendar and a stage in the churchyard.

The church also brought music: hymns, part-singing and choral harmony that became the harmonic language of Nigerian popular theatre and of the folk opera.

The school

Speech day was the annual theatre festival of colonial Nigeria. Schools staged Shakespeare, Greek scenes, moral dialogues and patriotic tableaux, and the best performers were known beyond the school. The school play was where a Nigerian audience first learned to sit in rows in the dark and watch a story that was not a ritual.

The teachers who directed these plays were the first Nigerian directors, and the plays they chose were the first Nigerian repertory.

The concert and the folk opera

The concert party combined a band, comedy and a sketch, and toured. Its Nigerian descendant, the Yoruba folk opera, added a continuous story, a company and a moral argument: Chief Hubert Ogunde's early work grew out of church and concert performance before it became a professional travelling theatre.

The folk opera is the missing link between colonial and post-colonial theatre, and it is the form most often left out of the syllabus.

The hall as a public space

The colonial hall - church hall, school hall, town hall, assembly hall - was the physical theatre of the period: a raised platform, a proscenium or a curtain, rows of chairs and a generator. It is still the commonest venue for Nigerian theatre, which is why the technical chapters on this shelf are written for it.

The hall made theatre a public event with a ticket, a programme and an audience of strangers - the conditions of a modern theatre, in a colonial building.

Reconstructing a lost repertoire

Very little of the colonial repertoire survives as a text. It survives in programmes, newspaper notices, school magazines, photographs and memoirs, and reconstructing it is a research exercise a student can actually do: the national archives, the university library, the church records and the family album.

Start with one institution - a school, a church, a town hall - and collect every theatrical event you can find over twenty years. List the title, the date, the venue, the company and the audience. Patterns appear quickly: the same plays, the same seasons, the same people directing.

Then read one surviving script, if there is one, against the notices. The gap between what was advertised and what was performed is the history: it tells you what the audience wanted, what the authorities allowed, and what the company could afford.

Teaching the form

The concert is a useful form for a first-year class because it is small, cheap and complete: a song, a sketch, a moral and an audience. Ask students to write and perform one in a single week, with one prop and no set.

Then ask them to write a second one for a different audience - a church, a school, a market - and compare. The exercise teaches audience analysis faster than any lecture, and it produces material a department can actually perform.

Exercises

1. Find a programme or a newspaper notice for a colonial-era concert and reconstruct its running order.
2. Write a ten-minute concert sketch in the 1940s style, with a song and a moral.
3. Compare the church cantata and the folk opera as forms: audience, story, music, purpose.

Where to read more

Ebun Clark, Hubert Ogunde: The Making of Nigerian Theatre (1979)

Karin Barber, The Generation of Plays (2000)

Yemi Ogunbiyi (ed.), Drama and Theatre in Nigeria (1981)

These are books to look for in a library or a bookshop. They are not on this shelf and ZikShare does not host them.